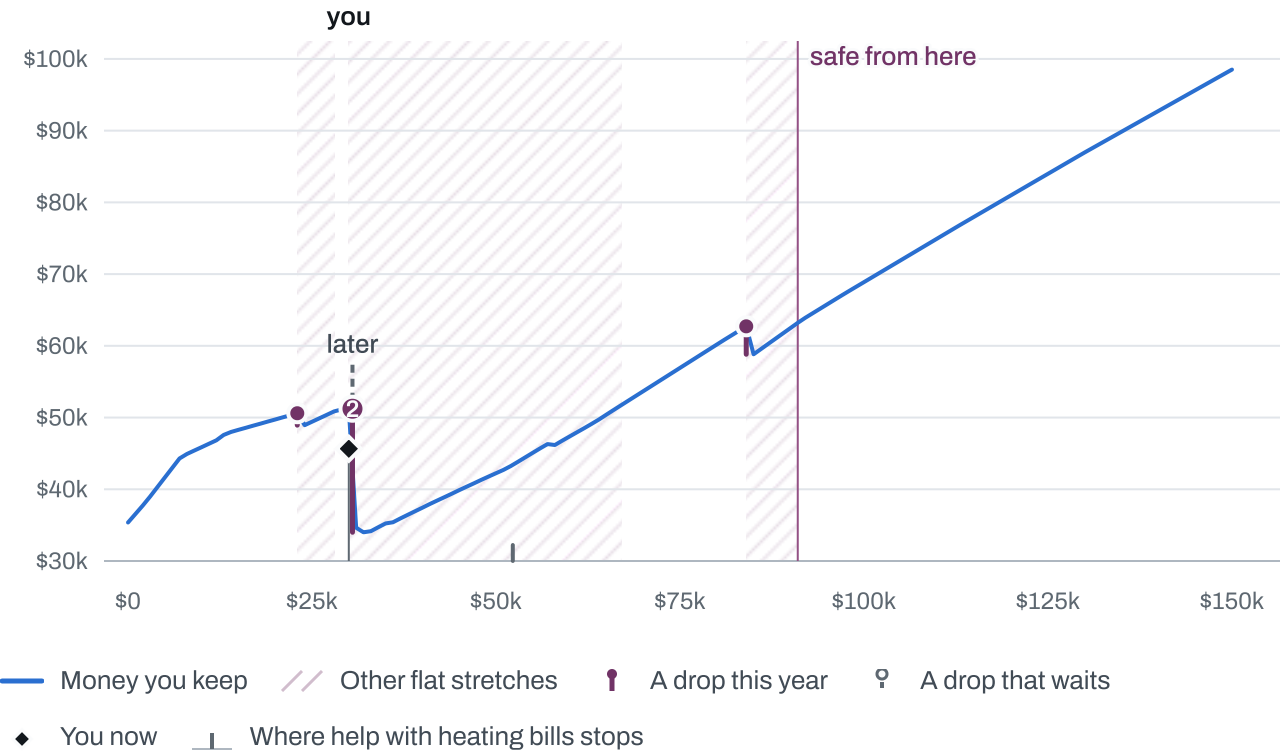


You are paid \$30,000 a year. You keep \$51,229. Near \$31,000, more pay can mean less money: past it you would keep about \$16,600 less a year. People call this a benefits cliff. At \$31,000, free early learning stops: about \$16,600 a year. But not that day. A child in it stays to the end of the next program year.

You keep more than your pay because help and tax money are part of it. \$16,908 of this is free early learning. It is not cash.

Money you keep in a year, as your pay goes up

Pay is by the year.



Above \$52,500 a year, you can no longer apply for help with heating bills in California. It is called LIHEAP. It is worth \$283 to \$594 a winter if you get it. About 1 in 10 families who could get it here do.

The picture covers all pay from \$0 to \$150,000. The side numbers start at \$30,000, not at \$0, so the drops are easy to see. These are estimates. They use the rules for 2026 in California.

Source: HotGap, from PolicyEngine with 2026 rules. These are your own numbers. Money kept is what is left after taxes and health-plan premiums.

The points the picture marks. Money kept is in dollars a year.

Your pay	You keep	Drop	On the picture
\$24,000	\$48,934	-\$1,666	A drop
\$30,000	\$51,229		You now
\$31,000	\$34,636	-\$16,593	A drop that waits
\$32,000	\$34,002	-\$634	A drop
\$85,000	\$58,820	-\$3,898	A drop
\$91,000	\$63,202		Safe from here

What ends, and when

\$24,000	Cash help ends. It is called TANF cash assistance. You keep about \$1,700 less.
\$30,000	Your own free state health plan ends. It is called Medicaid. Food help ends. It is called SNAP. Then help paying for health insurance starts. It is called the Premium tax credit.
\$31,000	Waits Free early learning would end. It is called Head Start. It does not end that day. A child in it stays to the end of the next program year. You would keep about \$16,600 less.
\$32,000	Your health plan would cost more here. You would keep about \$600 less.
\$51,000	A tax break for workers would end. It is called the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC).
\$58,000	Waits Your kids' free state health plan would end. It is called Medicaid. It does not end that day. Kids keep it to their next yearly check, up to 12 months later. Food help for moms and babies would end. It is called WIC.
\$85,000	Help paying for health insurance would end. It is called the Premium tax credit. You would keep about \$3,900 less.

What we assumed about you

Rent	None given. We counted no rent.
Child care	None. Nobody in the home pays for day care.

Help you get	Food help (SNAP), cash help (TANF cash assistance), a free state health plan (Medicaid), food help for moms and babies (WIC), and free early learning (Head Start). We count each as if you get it.
Not counted	Child care help (CCDF child care subsidy), housing help (Housing voucher), and help with heating bills (LIHEAP energy assistance). We count them as if you do not get them.
You	Age 30. A U.S. citizen. No one in the home has a disability.
Other money	Savings: None. No child support, SSDI or unemployment pay.
Hours	Not given. We assume full time.
Head Start	Worth \$16,908 a year to you: what day care would cost.
Health plan help	California Premium Subsidy, up to \$1,222 a year. It helps pay for health insurance. We counted it.

How common is this pay?

About 3 in 10 parents like you in California are paid \$30,000 a year or less. The count could be off by a few thousand dollars either way.

This says how common the pay is. It does not say what you will earn.

From U.S. Census Bureau survey data (ACS 2024, 1-year). Grown to 2026 dollars.

The lowest legal pay

California's lowest legal pay is \$16.90 an hour. Full-time work at that pay is about \$35,000 a year.

These are estimates. A case worker decides real help.

We use 2026 rules. The list above says what we assumed. If any of it is wrong for you, these numbers are off too. We did not ask about anyone in the home aged 65 or more.

We do not tell you what to do.